ART

Her Abiding *Humour*

Bani Abidi throws stones at giants in her latest exhibition, but she does so with tongue firmly in cheek

Bani Abidi is one of the funniest and most intelligent of subcontinental artists working today. Born and brought up in Karachi and now based between Pakistan and Berlin, Abidi has also spent regular time in India. In some of her early videos, there are great send-ups of the absurdities of Pak-India rivalries: two college students in America, one from each country, both played by Abidi herself, argue about the qualities of mangoes from their respective homes; two TV news readers, Pakistani and Indian (again played by Abidi), report on the same incident—the alleged stealing by India of an egg laid in Pakistan—from two opposing viewpoints. In other work, Abidi has examined the protocols and hardware of state control that one can find on both sides of the border: traffic barriers, intercom devices on gates, the way queues are made to form for official documents, the interminable pausing of public life when a high dignitary is about to drive past and so on.

While many of her works are embedded with a circuitry of dry humour, Abidi has also depicted in different ways the situations of people struggling to speak out against the powers that be, both in Pakistan and India. Her works based on the letters sent home by desi soldiers fighting in the trenches in France and Belgium is among the most moving things to come out of the art made to contemplate the 100th anniversary of the First World War.

In *The Song*, her latest show at Experimenter Gallery in Kolkata (on display till December 30), Abidi gives us work that has to do with sound and the absence of it. As a counterpart to the fading water-colour sketches of the Pakistani bloggers and journalists in *The Man Who Talked Until He Disappeared*, here Abidi gives us images that disappear step by step of contemporary Indian women activists and journalists speaking out against the multiple darknesses descending upon our country. *The Reassuring Hand Gestures of Big Men, Small Men, All Men* is again typical of Abidi—a simple device taken to another zone: photos of strongmen, dictators, generalissimos or quasi-democratic leaders are placed in a constellation of decoupages, the salutes, the pointed fingers, the determinedly clenched fists creating visual rhythms against cut off mouths, epauletted shoulders and squinting eyes, arriving at a composite portrait of the connected lies we have heard coming out of so many mouths over the last few decades, falsehoods that we can almost hear in chorus as we look at these horribly recognisable rectangular image-shards.

In the eponymous video *The Song*, we get yet another of Abidi's signature strands—a man in a space engaging in strange rituals that are at first completely mystifying and indecipherable. As the video progresses, the point of the old man's activity becomes poignantly clear and, like the other works in the show, it all has to do with what the ear can hear and what it yearns for. ■

Ruchir Joshi

SAMPLE THIS
Works from the collections *Woman Who Talked Until She Disappeared* (2022); (below) *The Reassuring Hand Gestures of Big Men, Small Men, All Men* (2021)







BANI ABIDI'S LATEST SHOW, *THE SONG*, IS ON DISPLAY AT EXPERIMENTER GALLERY IN KOLKATA TILL DECEMBER 30